

Neu-urbanism and agrario-curiosity

TREND 2 | US South

Abstract

The vibrant hyper modern utopian urban centers promised in the beautifully designed architectural models World's Fairs past have never materialized. While there is still an overarching trend of urbanization, there is the dialectical truth that the current urbanized population is dissatisfied with urban life.

The juxtaposition of a “back-to-nature” cultural zeitgeist and a desire to be in dense urban environments has created unexpected results. There is a fixation on the concept of walkable “15-minute cities” and insular neighborhoods that anchor the residents in a community. There is also a desire for a greater connection to the natural world. The gardening industry has seen huge growth after decades of slump. In a society so divorced from natural living, people want it all. They want to live in a large diverse space that offers the cultural variety that makes city-life interesting, at the same time they want a connection to a community and to the Earth.

The dream of a slick techno future is out of favor and a world in which the reality of our technological urban world can coexist with living a more naturally human life.

Localized incarnations

Community and home gardens

In the last 10 years community gardens have become vastly more numerous. Every neighborhood now has a community garden that is never in a deficit of volunteers. As you travel through Atlanta the number of raised vegetable gardens featured prominently in front yards is inescapable. There have been dozens of boutique house-plant shops that have popped up in virtually every neighborhood offering a “premium” gardening experience.

Insulation of neighborhoods

Atlanta, and the US writ large, have notoriously bad transit infrastructure due to decades of over indexing on the personal vehicle and extensive lobbying by the automotive industry at the expense of good mass transit. Atlanta has added 70,000/year for the last 10 years. Individual car transport is no longer tenable. As a result, Atlanta has formed a network of small neighborhoods with “downtowns.” This has always been a feature of Atlanta’s city planning, but what is new is the investment in these spaces. Every in-town neighborhood is now largely self-contained with its own grocery stores, pharmacies, restaurants, health care, dry cleaners, etc. The cross-town travel so common 15 years ago is largely unnecessary in the day-to-day life of most residents.

Business and design implications

Investment opportunities

There is a genuine market demand for investment in hyper-localized areas. Organizations that can figure out how to serve the needs and wants of small populations will see growth.

Bold visions of the future

Organizations that will read the cultural temperature in the room and begin to adjust their vision for the future and company purpose to project a future where technology, urbanism, and decentralized access to critical resources, and living in balance with nature will win trust and will win business.

The aesthetics and design philosophy of community-based techno-agrarianism

Nowhere is the changing desires of a vision of the future better exemplified than the rise of the “solar punk” aesthetic. First coming in gaming spaces, this art and design style is flourishing. It feels honest and harmonious. Its permutations can be found in every aspect of design. In physical spaces it manifests as earthy desaturated colors, natural and organic textures, and material honesty (the practice of not disguising one physical material as another. E.g., plastics that mimic wood). Organizations that embrace this change of the slick and smooth minimalism of the 2010s will succeed.